THE ROAD NOT TAKEN

Robert Lee Frost (March 26, 1874 – January 29, 1963)

The Poem

- "**The Road Not Taken**" is one of the most famous and popular poems by Robert Frost.
- It was published in 1916 as the first poem in the collection *Mountain Interval.*
- Its **central theme** is the divergence of paths, literally and figuratively.
- Its interpretation is noted for being complex and (**like the forked road**) potentially divergent.
- It is a **narrative poem** where the poet uses the conversational style to depict or describe vividly a quiet moment in the woods.
- It is also an example of a **formal verse** that consists of four stanzas of 5 lines each.
- The first line rhymes with the third and fourth, and the second line rhymes with the fifth (ABAAB).

History

- The poem is believed to have been written by the poet for his friend Edward Thomas.
- Edward Thomas was an eminent British poet, novelist, and essayist.
- Frost spent a good deal of his life in England, where Thomas and he used to go for long walks.
- Frost after coming back to New Hampshire in 1915 sent Thomas a copy of the poem who is believed to have commented that the poem is a tricky one.

The Essence of the Poem

- Frost's biographer Lawrence Thompson suggests that the poem's narrator is **"one who habitually wastes energy in regretting any choice made: belatedly but wistfully he sighs over the attractive alternative rejected"**.
- Thompson also says that when introducing the poem in readings, Frost would say that the speaker was based on his friend Edward Thomas. In Frost's words, Thomas was "a person who, whichever road he went, would be sorry he didn't go the other. He was hard on himself that way."

Themes

- **Choice**: The poem comprises uncertainty and perplexing situation of the minds of people about what they may face when standing on the verge of making choices. It is because life is full of choices, and the choices we make, define the whole course of our lives.
- **Individualism**: **American identity encourages individualism**; it is emphasized to be who you are and to freely express oneself. Robert Frost writes about the theme of individualism, and it comes down to being able to choose between the two roads, which seems to be an indecisive conclusion. The point is what one will decide for themselves. **With individualism comes independence, which is also another American identity**. The famous interpretation of this poem is that Robert Frost is referring to his main character as one who makes a decision to go against the norm of society, in other words, to be an individual. To be an individual and to act on your impulse and not 'the' impulse is not easy.

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- **The journey of imagination**: From the beginning of colonization, creativity has been a major American identity. Creativity is defined as engaging the imagination to arrive at original ideas and solutions. The journey of imagination is what sparks creativity, and creativity means thinking outside of the box; it means to think and go down a path that is less traveled.
- Thus, the poem also talks about being a non-conformist.

Setting

- The poem takes place in a forest in autumn, after the leaves have begun to change color.
- More specifically, the poem takes place at a spot in the woods at which a road forks into two. The two roads continue on from the fork, but the roads soon pass out of sight as they wind and bend in the undergrowth of the forest.
- A person standing at the fork can see that one of the roads is a bit grassier than the other, but they are equally strewn with freshly fallen leaves, and in truth both roads appear to be about equally worn.
- This makes the entire poem **an extended metaphor** in which the two roads that diverge symbolize life's many choices and symbolizes the path of nonconformity.

Mood and Tone

- The poem has a meditative and philosophical quality about it.
- The tone is serious and sombre but it is also a bit confusing at times. It brings out the elusiveness of choice(s).
- The language used is archaic and stylised. Creates an old world charm. Gives a pastoral feel.

The Dilemma

- It is one of Frost's most popular works. Some have said that it **is one of his most misunderstood poems**, claiming that it is not simply a poem that champions the idea of "following your own path", but that the poem, they suggest, expresses some irony regarding that idea.
- The **title of the poem** highlights and dramatizes this aspect.
- The expression of doubt runs in the poem from the first line until the last. **The expression of uncertainty about choices** and our natural tendency to surmise about consequences we may have to face **marks the central point of the poem**. However, what stays in the mind of the people is the philosophy of life and the **dilemma** of making choices.

Literary Devices Used

- **Metaphor**- the poem as an extended metaphor, the colour yellow, the forked road,
- **Imagery**- a very visually appealing poem. The poet makes uses of the 5 senses to create effect on the reader. The poet has used images of the sense of sights such as leaves, yellow woods, the road, etc.
- **Simile**- "as just as fair". It shows how the poet has linked the road less taken to the easy way through life.
- **Assonance:** Assonance is the **repetition of vowel sounds** such as the sound of /a/ and /o/ in quick succession in "though as far that the passing" and in "Somewhere ages and ages hence."

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- **Consonance:** Consonance is the repetition of consonant sounds such as /d/ in "two roads diverging in a yellow wood" and /t/ sound in "though as far as the passing there."
- **Personification:** Robert Frost has personified road in the third line of the second stanza. Here, it is stated "Because it was grassy and wanted wear" as if the road is human, and that it wants to wear and tear.
- **Parallelism:** Parallelism is the use of a source of words, phrases or sentences that have similar grammatical forms. Frost has used Parallelism in the poem such as-

"And sorry I could not travel both"

"And be only one traveler long I stood"

"And looked down once as far as I could"

Trivia

- Frost was nominated for the Nobel Prize in Literature 31 times.
- His poem "Fire and Ice" influenced the title and other aspects of George R. R. Martin's fantasy series *A Song of Ice and Fire*.
- Frost was honored frequently during his lifetime and is the only poet to receive four Pulitzer Prizes for Poetry.

Possible Questions (Short Answers)

- Discuss how the poem is a fine example of how Robert Frost uses ordinary situations and images as powerful symbols to talk about deeper truths of life.
- Do you think the title of the poem should have been 'The Road Taken'? Give reasons for your answer.
- "I shall be telling this with a sigh…" Is the poet happy or sad about the outcome of the choice he made long ago?
- Explain the following lines- "Oh, I kept the first for another day!/ Yet knowing how way leads on to way,/I doubted if I should ever come back."
- What possible theme(s) can you recognize from the poem? Elucidate with examples.

References

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THANK YOU